



Intel Classmate PC

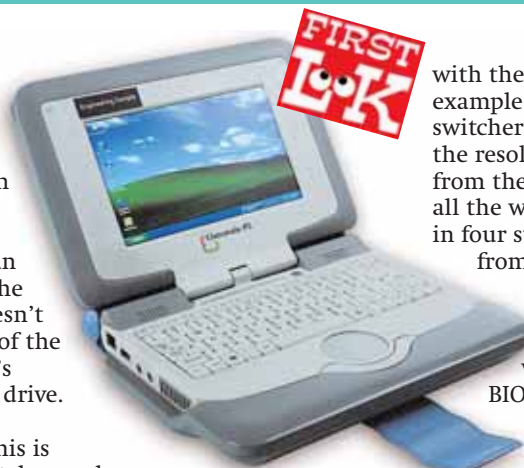
No Child's Play This

PCs have ushered in innovative ways of learning—self-paced, interactive, and fun. However, given the cost, using a PC in day-to-day educational activities is limited to degree students. Schools have their computer labs, but really, one does need access to one's own work and content at will—so Intel has come up with a novel solution, the Classmate PC, designed for school-goers. It looks like a toy—small buttons, round touchpad, dual-tone finish, etc. Open the lid and you are greeted with a little 800 x 480, 7-inch display, and a dinky little keyboard—probably good enough for a child. Switch on the machine and you are in for

a surprise—a full-blown Windows XP Pro!

Under the hood, running at 900 MHz, an Intel Celeron M does the duty. The machine doesn't feel sluggish, because of the 2 GB NAND Flash that's used instead of a hard drive. 2 GB space may seem laughable, but then, this is a concept machine; Intel has a definite plan to introduce higher-capacity NAND and eventually a hard drive. But for now, with Windows XP, the machine is left with just 700 MB of space for applications—too little.

The PC has one Ethernet and two USB ports, Wi-Fi, and earphone and mic jacks, but lacks an optical drive—understandable,



because the machine will be part of a network that includes a server from where content and applications will be pushed down. Security and content filtering is the objective here—schools can implement policies that, for example, restrict what the PC will be used for.

There is some Intel exclusive/enhanced software bundled along

with the machine. For example, the display switcher allows changing the resolution of the screen from the native 800 x 480 all the way up to 1280 x 786 in four steps—special drivers from Intel. In addition, there's Intel's Trusted Platform Module (TPM), which works at the BIOS level, locking the PC out if it fails to update its digital certificate from the school server. This makes the hardware useless if stolen.

Though a nice concept, acceptability will largely depend on the kind of e-learning content that can be delivered, how it will be made available, and the final barrier, cost. We expect that niggles like the storage will be ironed out in future iterations.

Kodak EasyShare V803

Average, We Say

Compact, sleek, and stylish best describe the V803. It is available in a range of eight eye-soothing colours from red to blue to pink; we received the matte-black one.

The clean layout of the keys along with a menu that is easy to navigate are plus points of the V803; the tiny zoom keys, along with the joystick, make navigation tough, though. Twenty-two different scene modes including panoramic stitching make this point-and-shoot camera novice-friendly. The range of ISO

speeds is from 80 to 1600; the large 2.4-inch LCD has clear and legible icons.

The inbuilt 32 MB of internal memory is not enough—just eight-odd photographs! Memory expansion is available, though, via SD/MMC cards. Surprisingly, the AV cable, a standard bundle with most digital cameras, is missing.

The panorama mode can be used for stitching three photos side by side, discarding the originals. The red auto-focus assist lamp is precise over a short range; accuracy degrades in dim lighting. The auto-focus is time consuming; it's buggy, focusing wrong areas in the viewfinder.

The snaps we took were well-exposed, with the right amount of colour. The sharpness was pleasing as



Rs 15K
it might
look
attractive

for an 8 MP camera, but there are better cameras available at that price point.

well. There was some amount of purple fringing, though. Kodak's inbuilt Perfect Touch technology auto-enhances the snaps with dynamic colours and contrast, while also adding up some noise, unfortunately.

Video mode allows taking 640 x 480 MPEG-4 clips at 30 fps. You can switch to a lower 320 x 480 to save space.

Overall, the Kodak EasyShare V803 is an average performer; priced at about

Specifications

Dimensions (W x H x D): 103 x 54.5 x 25 mm; weight: 141.5 gm; 8MP; zoom: 3x optical, 4x digital; battery: 1050 mAh; direct printing: ImageLink, PictBridge

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Web site: www.kodak.co.in
Price: Rs 14,999

RATINGS

Features	★★★★●
Build Quality	★★★★●
Image Quality	★★★★●
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●